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Let Gratitude and Optimism Move You Forward

The opening argument for this book's strategy drew on the big picture: we are living in a massively scaled, rapidly changing, complex, and multicultural world. We need a strategy to thrive in such an environment.

The closing case for this book's strategy draws from a very small picture: a snapshot from my years as a Jesuit seminarian.

After finishing college and graduate school, I was assigned to live in one of the United States' largest Jesuit communities, a hundred-strong household populated by saints, scholars, and eccentrics (often enough, all three descriptions fit the same person). The cast of characters included a sixtysomething priest that we might call "Free-Dog," a vague approximation of his nickname. Free-Dog, who had supposedly descended into premature but benign semilunacy, managed minor administrative matters within the community.

Free-Dog would make daily rounds of recreation and mailrooms, pushing around a cart stacked with office or cleaning supplies and providing running editorial commentary about the Jesuit colleagues who crossed his radar. He broadcast at such a high decibel level that anyone within a fifteen-yard radius could tune in to the analysis. Many community members were university professors, and Free-Dog wasn't much impressed by publications in prestigious journals or invitations to address academic conferences; he took particular delight in skewering these intellectual giants and cutting them down to size. Was he really nuts? Hard to say. He often said

what the rest of us were thinking but wouldn't dare utter in public. But because Free-Dog was supposedly a lunatic, he got away with it. Not a bad strategy.

A few weeks before I joined Free-Dog's community, I had been awarded a couple of minor academic distinctions at my university commencement. That was all Free-Dog needed to know about me. Forever after, when he saw me coming down the hallway, he would frequently announce with theatrical flair, "Hey, here comes Crissy Fraud," that is, here comes Chris, who thinks he's smart because he won some small-potatoes award at his college graduation. The greeting invariably cheered rather than rankled me. If Free-Dog was needling you, he probably liked you. The folks who really had to worry were those who didn't rate in his commentary at all.

I recalled the anecdote more than once over the months of writing this book. To be sure, I never felt like a fraud while writing, but I was keenly aware that I'm a less worthy messenger of its ideals than those profiled in its pages or countless others I could have included.

A chapter extolled the value of integrity, profiling Johnson & Johnson executives whose countrywide Tylenol recall set their company back some $100 million (back when $100 million was a lot of money). They stood up for their corporate values when compromising those values would have been easier and far less costly. Yet as I was writing about their integrity, I cringed to recall moments in my own corporate climb when the expediency of going along to get along won out over speaking truth to power.

Another chapter counseled freedom from disordered attachments when contemplating major decisions. We sometimes make lousy decisions in business or personal life not because we lack the facts or the intelligence to evaluate them, but because ambition, greed, or a dozen other private demons subtly cloud our better judgment. If I had heeded my own advice over the years, I might have better navigated my one or two (or few dozen) decisions that have been steered less by free pursuit of my life purpose than by pride, fear, or—let's not forget—lust.

Most fundamentally, this book has championed purpose beyond self. Think of Nanette Schorr lavishing her legal expertise on impoverished South Bronx mothers whose children have been placed in protective custody; through that often-frustrating work, Nanette is fulfilling her life purpose, which is to repair the world. Or picture Sr. Saturnina walking up and down the hills of a Caracas slum to teach children to read. Her example locked into focus the sometimes-obscure vision that is God's kingdom. It's not out there in the ethereal distance, over a mountaintop and beyond our lifetimes. Rather, as she put it, "se hace presente"—it's making itself present; it's here. Yes, it's fully alive as she helps children "to live with the dignity that corresponds to children of God's kingdom."

Like Sr. Saturnina, Nanette, and others profiled in these pages, I, too, aspire to a mighty purpose. My reading of my Christian tradition convinces me that I am here on earth to love and serve my neighbors. Yet my implementation of that lofty purpose leaves much to be desired as I reel through an often self-absorbed life more serving of self than serving of neighbor.

And so, as I polished this book's chapters, I sometimes felt a very unpolished vessel for its message. At worst, I felt almost like, well, Crissy Fraud. Who am I to peddle a strategy for living that I haven't perfected in my own life? The Christian apostle Paul summarized succinctly and well what often seems to be my life predicament: "I do not understand my own actions. For I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate" (Romans 7:15). Amen, brother Paul.

But my gnawing disquiet evaporated as I realized that my own quite-flawed humanity doesn't invalidate this book's strategy, but powerfully vindicates it. Indeed, my own shortcomings are the last, best argument for what this book advocates, and my frequently self-absorbed lurch through a confused and confusing world only underscores this book's central case: life is complex, massively scaled, and fast changing; we humans are innately weak, needy, prone to distraction and easily tempted off course. Marry our frailty to the vexing environment in which we live and work, and living

well becomes as challenging as assembling the pieces of a vast, complicated puzzle.

But even that isn't the best image. If it were only as simple as fitting puzzle pieces into a big picture, we would eventually complete the task. Rather, life more often feels like a puzzle in which some pieces are suddenly removed and new, unfamiliar ones dropped onto the pile. If the apostle Paul confesses that it was hard for him to stay on track, notwithstanding God's lightning-bolt intervention, of course the rest of us will struggle to make our way through the maze of present-day challenges. No wonder we sometimes become confused, frustrated, discouraged, angry, lost, or overwhelmed and end up, as Paul says, doing the things we hate.

So, how should we respond to the human predicament? We will either lead proactively or live passively, either take charge where we can or drift reactively on the tide of life's vicissitudes, either think hard about what our earthly journey is supposed to mean or try hard to avoid thinking about it.

This book is for those who opt for leadership and are willing to pursue a proactive, deliberately plotted approach to their most important business, the business of their own lives. That means starting with big-picture questions like why we are here on earth and systematically progressing through the nitty-gritty concerns of performing more effectively this very afternoon. We charted a three-part strategy for doing so: live for a mighty purpose, choose wisely, and make every day count. By threading an unchanging purpose and values through your ever-changing circumstances and major decisions, you will weave a life project that holds together as a unified tapestry. Work and home life will tie together, as will religious beliefs and everyday affairs.

Still, no strategy will succeed without courage, a deep-in-the-bones commitment to turn from what is destructive, false, or life sapping because we have glimpsed what is constructive, true, or life giving. And so we return to the unlikely warranty featured in this book's introductory chapter: "Most how-to books guarantee a result if only you read the book; this book guarantees no result if all you

do is read it." Our strategy will work, but only when transformed people devote courage, commitment, and will to it.

This book can't bring its strategy alive in another person's heart, but we can at least model the advice of an early guidebook to the Spiritual Exercises and "point, as with a finger, to the vein in the mine and let each one dig for himself."[1] And so, as you dig for renewed commitment and courage, start your excavation with gratitude and optimism.

Let Gratitude Catapult You Forward

Nikki Giovanni reminds us in one poem that "we are better than we think and not quite what we want to be."[2]

We can invigorate our approach to life by pondering both parts of what we might call Giovannni's axiom. First, we're better than we think we are. Second, we are not quite what we want to be or can be: we have more potential than we imagine.

The knowledge that we are better than we think we are ought to spark not arrogance but humble gratitude. Recall the employees of Catholic Health Initiatives who stand for the value of reverence and define it as "profound respect and awe for all of creation." As we race through our lives to catch the next train or squeeze in one more errand, we ought to pause occasionally, look around, and be awestruck by this marvelous world we are racing through.

The Buddhist monk Thich Nhat Hanh exhorted us to remind ourselves daily of the simple but profound blessing that we are alive in this marvelous world: "Every morning, when we wake up, we have twenty-four brand-new hours to live. What a precious gift!"

And Ignatius of Loyola reminded us that we ourselves are one of this world's greatest marvels. Look at the world with gratitude and awe, but look at yourself with the very same attitude. We are more talented, gifted, and resourceful than we ever take time to consider. In one spiritual exercise, Ignatius counsels us to bask gratefully in

the sheer wonder of our being by considering "how God dwells . . . also in myself, giving me existence, life, sensation, and intelligence; and, even further, making me his temple, since I am created as a likeness and image of the Divine Majesty" (#235).

Be grateful. Be grateful for your talents and gifts because they are the raw material out of which you will conceive and shape your life's purpose. Whoever we are, whatever our circumstances, we can, as Archbishop Óscar Romero once put it, "do something and do it very well," whether that is raising children, teaching them to read, keeping the streets safe for them, creating dignified jobs for their parents, erecting buildings that will safely shelter them, or thinking and praying benevolent thoughts for their future.

Be grateful because gratitude is what energizes and motivates us to pursue great purpose. As Ignatius, says, we each ought to "ask for interior knowledge of all the great good [we] have received, in order that, stirred to profound gratitude, [we] may become able to love and serve" (#233).

Lead with Optimism toward a Better World

Gratitude ushers in the optimism that we are capable of being more and better than we are today. We are not quite what we want to be—yet. But we can and will get there. It's worth pondering the fact that Giovanni delivered that poem some twenty-four hours after a deranged gunman had slain more than thirty students and staff at her university campus in the most horrific massacre ever of its kind. At such a moment, above all moments, we need to find the heart and voice to believe that we are better than we think we are.

All of us have been beaten down, disappointed, or hurt by the malfeasance of others, and we stumble, fail, and sin through our own poor choices. The optimistic are convinced that there are grace, mercy, second chances, and forgiveness in this world; we will

stand up again and walk forward. And when we don't have the strength to stand up and walk on our own, others will reach out to lift and steady us.

We are bundles of needs, wants, and desires. The optimistic among us believe that our desires and wants need not be enslaved by whatever unhealthy attachment currently preoccupies us or whatever shallow promise an advertiser might thrust in front of us. Rather, we can direct our desires toward some purpose greater than ourselves. We are capable of great vision and don't have to surrender to shortsightedness. We are capable of transcending ourselves, and we don't have to settle for some meager purpose that doesn't uplift us.

The struggle before us is to lead ourselves and our civilization to higher purpose, transcending the small-spiritedness typified in a recent U.S. presidential candidate's damning observation, "Politicians operate on the basis that this generation is too greedy to do anything for the next generation."[3] I can't judge whether this prominent figure has judged himself and his politician colleagues accurately, but I categorically reject his jaundiced judgment on the rest of us.

Politicians and the media may occasionally pander to some greedy, fearful, narrow-mindedness within us. But meanwhile, out here in the real world, legions of the great spirited are doing plenty for the next generation, loving and teaching our kids, sacrificing so they will be well educated, accompanying them through unexpected illness, and preparing a more beautiful and more interesting world for them by what we make, sell, or do. Indeed, if I started chronicling every example of such human goodness in even one small city, I would never finish the task; as the evangelist John wrote, "the world itself could not contain the books that would be written" (John 21:25).

We everyday visionaries are capable of leading civilization forward, no matter that we feel too human, too fragile, too distracted, too greedy, and too everything else for the task. Let's accept the

privilege and burden of leading ourselves, our loved ones, and our civilization, whatever our livelihoods and however modest our circumstances. With a clear strategy and the courage of our convictions, we can embrace great purpose, make good choices, and get things done every day of our complicated lives.

The time for the civilization of self is over. Let's start building the civilization of love.

Notes

Introduction

1. David W. Moore and Frank Newport, "People in the World Mostly Satisfied with Their Personal Lives," Gallup News Service, June 20, 1995, quoted in David Whitman, *The Optimism Gap: The I'm OK, They're Not Syndrome and the Myth of American Decline* (New York: Walker and Company, 1998), 3.
2. Quoted in Lawrence J. Lad and David Luechauer, "On the Path to Servant Leadership," in *Insights on Leadership: Service, Stewardship, Spirit, and Servant-leadership*, ed. Larry C. Spears (New York: John Wiley & Sons, 1998), 54.

Chapter 1

1. Conrad de Aenlle, "History Offers Hope and Fear for Kodak," *New York Times*, February 17, 2007.
2. "The World's Largest Corporations," *Fortune*, vol. 158, no. 2, July 21, 2008, p. 165.
3. Charles H. Duell, quoted in Henry Ehrlich, *The Wiley Book of Business Quotations* (New York: John Wiley & Sons, 1998), 190.
4. In 1800, four out of five people were self-employed. *Co-creation and Capitalism: John Paul II's Laborem Exercens*, ed. John W. Houck and Oliver F. Williams (Washington, D.C.: University Press of America, 1983).
5. See, for example, Wei Jiang and Sheena Iyengar research, Columbia University, in Barry Schwartz, Hazel Rose Markus, and Alana Conner Snibbe, "Is Freedom Just Another Word for Many Things to Buy?" *New York Times Magazine*, February 26, 2006, 15.